Cervical Collar

Category: **Medical, Healthcare & First Aid** Type: **Full SOP** Priority: **High** 2 labs

Covers these lab items: Cervical Collar; Cervical Colour Set

What it is used for

A cervical collar supports the neck and may help restrict cervical spine movement when clinically indicated. It should be selected, fitted, and monitored by trained healthcare or emergency personnel as part of an appropriate patient assessment and spinal motion restriction plan.

Main parts

- Rigid or semi-rigid shell provides structural support.
- Adjustable height or sizing mechanism helps fit the patient's neck where provided.
- Chin support helps position the lower jaw.
- Occipital support contacts the back of the head where included.
- Hook-and-loop straps or fastening tabs secure the collar.
- Padding improves comfort and helps distribute pressure.
- Sizing guide or measuring reference assists collar selection where supplied.

Before you start

1. Only trained healthcare or emergency personnel should fit a cervical collar.
2. Assess the scene and the patient according to the applicable clinical protocol; address airway, breathing, circulation, and immediate life threats first.
3. Select a collar size suitable for the patient's anatomy and the device instructions.
4. Inspect the shell, padding, straps, fasteners, and adjustment mechanism for damage or contamination.
5. Explain the procedure to the patient when possible and obtain assistance to maintain appropriate head and neck alignment.
6. Check for conditions requiring special assessment, including breathing difficulty, neck deformity, or pressure-sensitive skin.
7. Perform hand hygiene and use appropriate PPE when exposure to bodily fluids is possible.

How to use

1. Position the patient and maintain manual stabilisation when indicated by the clinical protocol.
2. Measure or estimate the required collar size using the manufacturer's sizing method without forcing the neck into a new position.
3. Adjust the collar height or configuration before fitting when the device design requires it.
4. Place the collar around the neck using the trained technique while maintaining the patient's alignment.
5. Position the chin support under the chin without forcing the head or jaw into an uncomfortable position.

6. Secure the fastening straps evenly so the collar is stable but does not obstruct breathing or circulation.
7. Check that the collar does not press excessively on the throat, jaw, ears, or skin.
8. Reassess airway access, breathing, comfort, skin condition, and neurological status as clinically appropriate.
9. Continue monitoring the patient and maintain the wider spinal motion restriction plan where indicated.
10. Remove or adjust the collar only when directed by the applicable clinical protocol or qualified clinician.
11. Clean and disinfect reusable components after use according to the manufacturer's instructions and facility policy.
12. Document fitting, patient response, skin checks, and any changes according to clinical requirements.

⚠ Safety

- A cervical collar does not replace airway management, clinical assessment, or other indicated spinal precautions.
- Do not delay lifesaving care to fit a collar.
- Do not force the neck into alignment or tighten the collar enough to impair breathing or circulation.
- Monitor for breathing difficulty, increasing pain, pressure injury, vomiting, or neurological changes and seek immediate clinical reassessment.
- Do not use a cracked, deformed, contaminated, or incorrectly sized collar.
- Follow local protocols for spinal motion restriction, patient movement, infection control, and equipment cleaning.

Care & storage

- Clean and disinfect reusable parts using approved products and manufacturer instructions.
- Inspect the shell, padding, straps, and fasteners for cracks, wear, and loss of secure fastening.
- Check adjustable parts for reliable operation before returning the collar to service.
- Store the collar clean, dry, and protected from deformation.
- Discard single-use components after use and remove damaged equipment from service.

Common mistakes to avoid

- Selecting an incorrect collar size or fitting it without trained assistance.
- Forcing the head or neck into a position during application.
- Tightening the collar enough to restrict breathing or cause excessive pressure.
- Failing to reassess the patient or check for skin pressure after fitting.

Disclaimer: This SOP is prepared from general information available on the internet. For detailed instructions, refer to the manufacturer's original manual / file.